to the petition filed by Afzal's family are also arguing that Afzal must hang so that Indian democracy and the loved ones of those who died defending the Indian Parliament may rest in peace. The dignity of the Indian republic hinges on the lever that will catapult Afzal into the empty space under the gallows in Tihar Jail. As the noose tightens, our polity will blossom with renewed vigour.

In championing capital punishment, Barkha Dutt also joins the illustrious pantheon of the good and the great in India, such as Shri L.K. Advani, Shri Maninderjeet Singh Bitta (of the All India Anti-Terrorist Front) and Shri Buddhadev Bhattacharya who have all, from time to time, publicly expressed their desire to see different people hanged to death. Politicians such as Ghulam Nabi Azad who have apparently pleaded for a 'postponement' of Afzal's execution in view of 'prevailing circumstances' are as cynical as those (especially in the BJP) who demand that Afzal be hanged as soon as possible while simultaneously demanding that the unfortunate man called Sarabjit Singh who is held in death row in a Pakistani prison be released.

Broadly echoing the Ghulam Nabi Azad line (with some nuanced differences) is the gerontocracy of the Communist Party of India, which has not found fault with the verdict, only expressed an apprehension about the consequences of its execution. The central leadership of the Communist Part of India (Marxist) has maintained an undignified and convenient silence, even though its prominent legislator in Kashmir, Yusuf Tarigami, has publicly opposed the death penalty for Afzal. Farooq Abdullah of the National Conference in Jammu and Kashmir has suddenly discovered what he calls 'innocence' in Mohammad Afzal Guru in an interview given to Karan Thapar, and this is somewhat belated, because he never said a word about the 13 December case while he was a coalition partner of the then ruling NDA. Presumably, the National Conference's sensitivity to the issue of human rights violations in Jammu and Kashmir has an inverse relationship to the fact of its being in office in that state.

Even Rahul Mahajan, the illustrious son of the late BJP leader Pramod Mahajan, has attempted to pave his entry into the bosom of nationalist politics (somewhat derailed by the embarrassing episode pertaining to the circumstances that led to the public disclosure of his flirtation with cocaine) by participating in a BJP Yuva Morcha (Youth Front) meeting in Mumbai. His indignation at the prospect of Afzal continuing to live was evident when he said, 'The way the nation is being held at ransom by certain people [asking